

2022 Maritime Family Vacation: compiled

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Maritime Vacation: Day 1

2022-07-28

We arrived in Port aux Basques on time for the 11:45 ferry to North Sydney. The kids ooo'd and aww'd over the size of the boat.

Wally met some friends at the dog park, not knowing at the time that one of those friends would be his neighbour for the trip across. We had a hard time finding the kennel, not realizing it would be 1) outdoors on the deck, and 2) have no one attending. Wally's park friend was happy to see him (his owner, the girl with the leg tattoos, told me as we were leaving the boat that Wally's appearance calmed her dog down).

For the first part of the journey we did not have a cabin. We sat in a row of 4 (+1 in the row ahead) on deck 7. Soon after eating our lunch we were called to the purser's office for a cabin! R and I got a nap in. Me and the kids ate Sundaes on

deck 9. We dined in the Met for supper (2 stars) and that was that.

We got to the hotel by 6:30 local time. We're in the Mi'kmaq community of Membertou. T, M, W, and I walked to the playground that the kids spotted as we neared the hotel. A somewhat rundown daycare playground. They enjoyed themselves.

Back to the hotel for a swim. I had a lot of fun going down the slide with M and L (they still need dad... however by the end L went alone multiple times). They were well ready for bed. L didn't want to leave swimming. Stuck his tongue out and called me a loser over and over. I responded with my own tongue. That laughed him out of his evening tantrum.

Minor chaos getting them all asleep in the hotel room. They are snoring as a 10-hour YouTube clip of white noise plays from this machine. It has been going for 34 minutes and 55 seconds.

I forgot they don't sell beer in convenience stores here. Good grief. Could use a dry night...

Maritime Vacation: Day 2

Woke up at the Hampton Inn... about 20 times. Theodore constantly ripped the blanket off of me and/or took up more of the bed than Rebecca does. Terrible night sleep, but it was to be expected.

I headed out to Rotary Park for my first round of Maritime disc golf. Ben also designed this course—I could sense this while I was playing it... but I confirmed it after I finished. It was a lovely disc golf experience. A lot of holes that I would love to play again. All of them really. Excellent course.

Back to the hotel for breakfast (kids and R had already eaten and swam at this point... bless her.).

Tried to point out some of the things I have found interesting in my years doing this drive to the kids. Bras d'Or Lake, The Big Red Barn, Canso Causeway, Deer Warning signs... Highway speed signs. Ok. Yeah. The quarry near the Causeway and the large cargo ship docked to it was probably the highlight.

We stopped at the Irving after the Causeway and checked out the tiny dog park. I bought a hot dog. Theodore bought a tray of veggies (love to see it), T and L got Lunchables. I also bought 6 Propeller IPAs. My old Halifax goto beer.

Unnecessary stop in New Glasgow to briefly see the cousins... in a Wendy's parking lot. I quickly had enough of that shit show and got the journey back on track after a healthy purchase at the Atlantic Superstore of fruit, cheese snacks, yoghurt drinks, and a chicken sandwich for R.

We stopped in Oxford, saw the giant blueberry, and relieved ourselves in Tims.

We arrived in Moncton an hour or so (?) later, surprised that our 'Holiday House' was so close to the highway exit. Lovely old spacious split-level in a nice, if isolated, part of town. The dogs got to know each other very well and played nicely during our first hours here.

After a lasagna and garlic bread supper (thanks to Adam and Jill), we headed to Stephanie and Neil's house for a quick visit with family. We took a detour to the Champlain Mall so that R could pick up her Crocs ordered-to-store from Globo. She was successful. L wanted a water. I purchased a water... and a regular fries from New York fries. Rebecca mentioned that she noticed multiple women giving me eyes. The tall dark-haired thin woman also waiting for a New York Fries order was one of them. That made me feel nice. R and her new \$35 coral-coloured Crocs is most lovely (even more so for noticing AND telling me).

We had a nice visit to Stephanie's house. Her house is lovely. Met Laura, saw all of the Leahy's and Grandma (who is looking great). It came up when leaving, from Stephanie, that I was the oldest cousin and that Chelsea had that as one of her secret questions. I felt that connection then. We lost touch with Christopher, Stephanie, Chelsea, and Colin after the big family blow up at the cabin. We were so close. They were our Preston, Jack, Lucy, and Berry. We had a such a short time together and we didn't know it.

But, the connection is still there. Looking forward to the wedding and getting to speak to them all some more. I shall be slightly inebriated and possibly slightly high. I think that may help.

Ok. R is calling me to bed. Quite evening. Kids in bed by 10. All Dressed Lays, Propeller IPA x2. Bed.

DOUBLE RAINBOW  while driving from Champlain Mall to Stephanie and Neil's.

Maritime Vacation: Day 3

The day started with a round of CDT DGC. I played well. Really fun course. Short holes, tight lines. Ben Smith trees all over it.

Went to Sobeys after DG to buy supplies for the day.

Magnetic Hill Zoo in the morning. Lawrence was difficult to start, but once he started seeing the animals, especially the lions he came around (a little). Highlights: seeing the lions get fed raw chicken through the fence with L in my arms, watching the river otters with M—we waited and waited for them to climb onto their structure, others left, we stayed, and then we had the otters to ourselves for a moment and they put on a little show.

Once it started getting hot, we all quickened are steps toward the exit. Escaped the gift shop with minimal damage done.

Took Theodore to the Champlain Mall to get his haircut (in Walmart) and to buy shorts. We skipped into the mall. A fun and rare 1-on-1.

Wedding time. All dressed up. Short sweet ceremony outside of the Royal Oaks Golf Club. To the deck for champagne and muscles (I finally tried one! I didn't die and it was... alright. Rubbery.) Grandma bought me a beer :)

Kids had a great time at the wedding but it was a challenge. Waiting for food, for speeches, for dances. Everything is a wait for a kid.

Nice buffet meal. Nice ceremony. Some fantastic dance performances from Theodore, Marianne, and Lawrence (L had no fear and danced his heart out).

Tomorrow... Magic Mountain! (I'm tired! So tired!)

Maritime Vacation: Day 4

How'd the day start? I'm well into my reserve beer—double IPAs. I'll give it a shot.

Day started with a sleep in. Woke at about 8:45. Time to get ready for the Magic Mountain. To the park by 10 or so.

It was hot when we got there and just got hotter and hotter. Wave pool and the Lazy River to start things off. One of the middle looping slides (repeated later with Marianne, Preston, and Adam—lost my sunglasses temporarily on that one. Lifeguard hero to the rescue.)

So many wonderful bums (blonde with 2 children in the line up who described all of her tattoos and how they related to the children. damn.)

Ok. The beer is making me speak truth. Stop it.

Been down one time
Been down two times
I'm never going back again

(The blow-up with R can be read about in my other notes... wherever the hell they may be.)

🎵 Dragonette (Martina)

Lots of nice moments in the evening. Good times with T in the swings and the Sidewinder. Happy to goad Jenn into riding the Swings with Berry. Dancing in front of funny mirrors on the way out.

PEI bound tomorrow.

Up alone. Drinking. Listening to Robyn. So much love for her music and her.

Her dancing during <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ui1JeOSdIIA> fills me with acceptance. A vulnerable masterpiece. High art.

The official video. Haven't watched it in years. Still wildly great. I love love love her dancing. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=F6ImxY6hnfA>

Maybe I should get a tattoo. The things I and my kids love.

1) Shredder's Revenge 2) Robyn Dancing Silhouette 3) Disc Golf 4) Star Wars

This life is half-over. At best.

I'm going to bet this is the only one. The only life I get.

Playing Disc Golf feels like a good way to spend it. Hanging with my kids, too. Today was a special day. I can love so much. My love has limits. As all love should.

Taylor. Another Queen. A young queen.

August. Welcome. Show me a way. Don't slip away.

Mini golf was insane. Theodore is ultra competitive. Will have to bring him mini-golfing and disc golfing alone. I did appreciate R using Disc Golf as a reference for how to play mini golf. Not many kids get that reference.

I am obsessed with women.

Sarah. Taylor. Adrienne. Martina. Tegan. Sara. Stevie. Robyn. Natalie. Kylie. Lauren. Dolores. Karen. Haley.

Maritime Vacation: Day 5

Woke up (after too little sleep... see daily notes for a hint of what I was up too...) groggy and achy. Coffee from Tim's on the way to CDT DSG for a second round. Needed to poop during most of it, which kind of ruined it.

Came back and packed up like a mad man.

Failed brunch at iHop. No reservation. Oh well!

Kids enjoyed the bridge crossing. It is a marvel. T and I spent a little time at the monument to the bridge's construction.

At the Borden boardwalk we ate Hamburgers at Classic Burgers. L and I devoured ours. Disappointed in the rest of em! Those burgers were \$8 (L and M) and \$13 (T, R, and me) apiece.

We broke off from the rest of the caravan and arrived in Summerside mid-afternoon to visit Colin and Rebecca in their downtown home. It was being painted a vibrant blue when we got there.

Beautiful location and a beautiful heritage home. ...

Evening swimming

Stars and Hot Rod

Maritime Vacation: Day 6

Hillcrest: SNAKES, Birdies, and Beauty

Pulled into Hillcrest on a sunny morning. Red clay dirt road off the highway—Frisbee Lane. Instantly charmed and excited.

Great birdies on 4 and 16. Almost ace on 13 (birdied).

Lost the disc that I found in Moncton on Hole 17. Bummer. It gave me the best shots of the day. Looks like I'm in the market for a Ricky Wysocki Teebird3.



Aug 2, 2022 at 10:58 AM—Tee of 4.

Aug 2, 2022 at 10:58 AM—Tee of 4.



Aug 2, 2022 at 11:00 AM—Tee shot (!)

Aug 2, 2022 at 11:00 AM—Tee shot (!)

Ripley's was a mild hit. Overly expensive. The huge LightBright was a highlight, especially for R.



Aug 2, 2022 at 3:31 PM—R completing her Robot.

Aug 2, 2022 at 3:31 PM—R completing her Robot.

Theodore's dreams will be haunted by the shrunken head.

Kids had slightly more fun in the maze.

Cows in Avonlae (a/c busted at the Boardwalk location). Kids fussy until we got there.

Cooked BBQ chicken for all.

Calm evening of swimming and star gazing by the fire pit in front of Jenn and Paul's holiday home.

We talked of the entrainment of the crickets song. We wondered about the stars and satellites so clearly visible.

Maritime Vacation: Day 7

Went to Hillcrest again, but this time CK met me—his first time playing the sport. We had a great time chatting and throwing frisbees. A trip highlight for me.

Rushed to Cavendish from the course to meet the gang in Sandspit. Going into this leg of the trip I thought that Sandspit would be a highlight. It was a flop. Too crowded, too many rides down, others were alternating. Marianne was the worst height for the park, unable to go on much of anything that wasn't made for toddlers, alone or with an adult.

I think I salvaged some fun out of it with Go-Karts...which almost turned into a bad time. I bought tickets for a double cart for M and I (since she got the least enjoyment out of the park...). R bought T a ticket so he joined us in the line-up. He didn't meet the height requirement, which we only found out when he was taken out of his kart and measured. He was crushed. Thankfully, one of the kind attendants said he could ride with me in the double kart after going with M. I gave them a good fast kart ride each. Lots of passing and tight turns.

Beach in the afternoon. Bit of a shit show (as most things have tended to be). Jill and Adam, and Rebecca parked at a different beach up the road (I biked from the cabins). We were under the impression that dogs were permitted, but they most definitely were not (\$125 fine). So that meant Mom and Dad were out (they took Bobby and Molly back, Wally was being crated anyhow). L wanted none of the beach and didn't make it out of the van. M was fussing to go home minutes after arriving. R took them both home. I stayed with T. He had a great time. He found a spoon.

Every one was tired in the evening. Quiet evening.

(In the morning I woke with a fat lip. Must have been bitten by a bug overnight. Lip was swollen all day. Benadryl knocked me out cold ~10pm)

Maritime Vacation: Day 8

Shining Waters

Packed up our cabin first thing in the morning as we were being moved from #3 to #1 midday (the cabin staff were kind enough to move our things for us).

Arrived at Shining Waters around 10:30am and spent the entire day there. Kids took in all of the rides. Line ups for the water slides were long all day. I went down one of the body slides with M. It was fun, but short.

Day was a scorcher. Shade and liquid for survival.

I ordered beavertail wrapped hotdogs and poutine for lunch. Greasy and delicious.

Colin and Rebecca met us at the park with Emily and Alice. Was nice for the families to meet up again.

I got my wish of getting the kids to the Toy Factory. They made off with modest purchases (bookmark painting kit for M, black dragon for L, T saved his money).

Supper Search Swimming R went to the outdoor pool (she played volleyball with T and Lucy a few days ago in the indoor pool) M did a front flip in the water and learned to put her face in the water (w/o googles!) Wally-less

Maritime Vacation: Day 9

(Writing this a 4 days after based on quick jot notes made on the evening of Day 9)

Jot Notes

Saltwater kisses Sea shells M Cracked sea shell art Live Crab

Kings Pine

Sally's, Catch, Soccer, bike ride with M, fire, ghost pepper chips

From memory

The day started wonderfully. A bike ride to the beach (family via van). Dad, Preston, and Lucy joined us. The rest (not including mom — sick) went to Charlottetown for the morning.

The weather has been perfect the entire time.

Brackley Beach was busy by 10, but not overly so. Populated with like-minded vacationers. I combed the beach for shells and found a few. Each one that I found fit into a one of the other found shells. Ended up with 4 that stowed away nicely into the largest shell that required the most daring to retrieve (hardly any daring at all).

The water was healing. Cold with warm currents. Enveloping vigour and rejuvenation. I saw a crab scuttle away along the bottom, its image mirrored and wavy but clear from above the water. I walked away and called out to T who begged

that I go back and catch it (to eat!). I was too far away to go back. Seconds later, T found one and called me over. R tried to pick it up and it pinched her. It pinched me too. I managed to get it on another try and held it up for all the kids to see. It was missing its right arm (I would have liked to see how that happened!)

R joined me in the water. I brought her down into the water and we shared a salt water kiss.

M created beautiful ephemeral art at the water's edge. Then we left.



Aug 5, 2022 at 12:40 PM—She worked very hard on this. I love it so much.

If only every day could start that way. The bittersweetness of vacation highlights... of any highlight.

I texted Ben Smith the night before, letting him know that I played two of his courses — Rotary Park in Sydney and CDT in Moncton (Riverview). I let him know that I loved playing them both and that tomorrow (today) I would be playing Rose Valley. He suggested King's Pine instead and boy am I glad I took that advice. What a marvel. Beautiful rectangular wooded lot turned into what will be a premier disc golf destination in the not-too-distant future. The trees are tall and covering. The fairways are fair and interesting. The green growth and the elevation down to the elevated basket of 13 filled me with disc golf glee (it helps that I birdied it in spectacular fashion. Straight tee shot with Origin. Flex anhyzer PD to the basket.)

There was a pristine premium mid-range (Westside Warship) lying on the top of basket 10. It had a name on it. I took it. I also took a factory second Mako 3 from the clubhouse. That one had a hard to read name and number. I cannot justify why I did this. It was not a nice thing to do. Back in CB I had lost my (only ace) Kona Panis Mako3 and my Latitude Trust within a day of each other. Losing those discs bummed me out so much that I lost my enjoyment of the sport for a short time. The Mako3 especially was a special disc, not only for the ace. So yeah. No justification, just butthurt over not taking care of my own discs. Now I have passed on that hurt to others... but man do they both fly well! I love both of these discs. Used them both in my 48 round yesterday (2022-08-08). I don't regret taking them. That's an unfortunate part of who I am. It begun as a new teenager—the mischievous hobbit of stealing Calvin and Hobbes books (thanks, Bradford!). Sorry to everyone who has come up against that part of me.

King's Pine. Can't wait to play it again!

Maritime Vacation: Day 10

Packing until 5 minutes past check-out time Driving through Rose Valley and saying goodbye to idyllic PEI

Drive ideas:

1. Family Road Trip (boardgame)
2. Wally's (ice cream shop) with championship level disc golf course built designed and built by Ben Smith.

Antigonish Zinger. Made a couple of pee stops on the way to Baddeck. One was the Irving in Antigonish. There was a KFC and a Burger King attached. A Whopper was my first choice, but he BK was not serving Beef that day... Zinger from KFC it was. It hit a spot. Ok. That's enough of that.

We enjoyed a game of mini-golf at the Red Barn. I haven't recorded the scores yet. It was close between R and I. She won by a stroke after a strong back 9. Rebecca and Marianne were the only ones to birdie. Rebecca got 2 of them.

Ice cream in downtown Baddeck.

T - Moonmist
M - Moonmist
L - Bubblegum
P(Reston) - Moonmist
R - Blue Raspberry Sorbet in waffle
J - Orange in waffle

Edinburgh wool blanket (Inverary inn). Each of the double beds in our room in the Wagon House has a lovely wool throw. I want to steal it (**2022-08-07 14:04**: I didn't).

Maritime Vacation: Day 11

The final day.

Alarm did not go off. I am to blame. Woke at 7:45, fun time in the shower, got to restaurant by 8:30, car packed by 9:15, left at 9:35. Arrived at ferry in real good time—10:10. American Top 40 from August 1970 was playing on the radio.

Andy Williams song that Beyonce sampled. Let It Be. Itsy Bitsy Teenie Weenie Yellow Polkadot Bikini. Ohio. Good Vibrations.

What a time to be alive.

I write this from Deck 9 aboard the *Blue Puttees*. At the Ice Cream shop (we ate ours in the cabin this time — T and M went up together and bought theirs. T was nervous. M excited. Glad they made it together. A happy moment shared.)

Just visited Wally on the deck Kennel. I got the impression from a Westie owner that his piercing bark was well known in the area. I took him out for a short walk and pee on the deck and put him back in with his daily tooth-brush treat. He'll be fine. He's been in a lot of different situations on this trip and has handled them all like a champ. He'll be as happy as any of us to see the green house.

(Apparently Westie's are breed that started with the Cairn.)

2022-08-07 15:42

Theodore and Marianne just came by. They were out of the cabin, exploring on their own. I sent them up to the Sun Deck. They came back down after 5-10 minutes and asked if they could go to the store. I gave T the cash we owed him (\$25, an extra \$2). He offered to buy M something. She negotiated a budget of \$6 in front of a line-up for ice cream. Approving smiles and eyes of masked faces from onlookers. They are having a proper ferry experience... even if the ferry isn't providing the entertainment it once did (movies, arcade, live shows). I expect them back soon.

Gassed up in Codroy. Saw a moose about 10km from Corner Brook. Small one on the road who quickly darted off once it noticed my headlights. Good instincts on that one.

Everyone was happy pulling up to the green house.